

PONDERER (OF OCEANUS) SCENE

"wheeo". We see darkness, the ticking of a clock can be heard, the second hand clicking forward every moment. The low ticking is interrupted by, "Doctor?" Another moment passes, and with more urgency the older, feminine voice calls again "Doctor?". We pan out, pulling back from the perspective of the oozing doctor to a corner of the room. Seeing the room now it's cozy and warm. A rustic aesthetic uncommon in comparison to the plated, dirty, gray sheen of Theosis and its chambers. Several potted plants dot the corners of the room, and one fern stands next to the end table closest to the seat where the doctor sits. "It's been 4 rotations since they let me see my husband." As the woman speaks, "wheooo" we hear the sound of playing in the corner once more, a small child plays with a Goblin Junkcycle, his hands up to his face are covered in streaks like lightning of gummy flesh, and the child's eyes are bloodshot. "They keep telling me my husband will be back to service in no time. But when... when our son can't," the tears well up in her eyes, she chokes.

"Mrs. Regreqt, you've nearly completed your optional mental health leave following what happened 52,920 offsets back" the doctor remains controlled, "do you feel adequately prepared to re-enter service at the end of this rotation?"

"I have to, this time away from service has drained my credit trust. But it gnaws at me, and with my husband in treatment... Conner faces humiliation everyday. Had my husband just checked the gauge one more time--" "Naomi," the doctor glances aside to the digital clipboard on the end table near him, "this may seem unorthodox, but I may be able to pull some strings, the researchers at Unity-22 have afforded me certain privileges, if you'd be willing to work with me." A pause, "Under certain circumstances, I am able to reach into the mind of others, that is part of why I've been assigned this service. The company would like for me to use this ability with my clients, and if I make them happy I may be able to ask a favor. Find out about your husband."

The doctor passes the contracting clipboard to Naomi. Our perspective cuts to see Naomi's reaction, "This.. I need time."

"There won't be another appointment. This is it."

We cut, and zoom from above towards the signature line. Naomi's finger presses against the screen, "eik" a prick, a small trickle of red blood seeps into the screen. She draws her hand away, and "Naomi O. Regreqt" appears to the left of a digital fingerprint. We see the doctor form an appendage with small lightly waving tendrils that wraps around Naomi's right hand and begins to stretch across her forearm.

"My husband failed us. Failed Conner, and now he's draining our trust. That despicable man." Naomi startles, her eyes grow wide, "How is he saying this." The tendrils encircling her arm, begin to bare down, digging deeper.

The doctor's mind is somewhere and we travel with him. Now we see a room: bare features, medical equipment and Naomi laid on a clinic loft. A dark-skinned figure with pink hair, and a constellation printed below their left eye ridge stands over Naomi. "Thank you for your cooperation at this time Naomi, the

confidentiality breach by your son Conner regarding your husband's closure may be forgiven as of your volunteering. We will now begin: How do you remember Band 4?" The figure's dark green eyes shine magenta for a moment.

Darkness. We're back in the doctor's office. "We will now begin: How do you remember Band 4?" the doctor's limb recoils back, "Your husband received closure."

Our perspective looking at the doctor and Naomi begins to slowly turn in the room towards the wall we'd previously been looking into the room from to see a long mirror bolted to the wall. We push forward until the mirror fills our entire perspective and then we keep going, pressing against the glass, pushing through it, into a cold dark clinical room, four men in coats watching the room with the doctor. And the clock "tick, tick, tick".